

Dear Future Eric,

We are currently approaching the end of the Fall 2025 semester. It has been a hectic semester, but we learned a lot, especially in our XAI course with Dr. Bent. Hopefully, you remember this, but we had to read a book for her class (yes, even if you are not the best at reading, hopefully that has changed). Anyways, the book we decided to read was *Unmasking AI: My Mission to Protect What Is Human in a World of Machines* by Joy Buolamwini. Throughout this book, we were exposed to a lot of interesting topics on how AI can harm and oppress society. This letter is for you and is meant to serve as a reminder of the topics we learned throughout reading this book.

One of the things I hope you have not forgotten is the author's idea of the coded gaze. Joy describes how code can embed preferences and prejudices of power into the technology that developers build. This can even occur unintentionally. There will always be bias from the creator. So, regardless of what aspect of data science you are working on, from machine learning to data engineering to analysis, you need to remember this, especially as we move up the corporate ladder and grow as leaders in industry. It is important to remember Joy's notion that this coded gaze is not only limited to racism or sexism, but can also extend to other exclusions like ageism, ableism, and any other forms of exclusion. This aligns closely with what we learned in our MIDS ethics courses, and it reinforces that nothing in AI is ever truly neutral.

Another part of the book that stood out to us was when Joy shared her narrative about the time that facial recognition software did not work correctly on her and could not recognize her face. In her story, she shares that she shone lights on herself and tilted her head in every direction, and yet the system still barely recognized her. Yet it worked immediately on her white roommate. This was extremely shocking and disturbing when reading, and it gave us a real case where this occurred; it was no longer something we just read about in a slide deck from class. So, as another reminder, as you go about doing your job, please remember to ask yourself who the models we are deploying for are and what the main goal is. This example turned algorithmic bias from an abstract concept into a real and harmful one, and it's important to remember that fairness and robustness matter more than just accuracy metrics.

Another interesting part of the book was the discussion about the Shirley cards during the film development era. Essentially, what this was about was that during this era, the film was calibrated and optimized to portray lighter skin tones. Ultimately, when computer vision came into play, the same data was incorporated into those systems as well. This just highlights that even modern technologies may have underlying biases due to inherited

biases already existing from previous data. I hope this serves as a reminder, especially as we look towards the past for data collection.

I am not certain what the realm of generative AI looks like in the future. However, currently, there is a lot of talk about the improvement of generative AI being used to create synthetic images of political and popular figures in unrealistic or misleading scenarios. Currently, it is Sora (developed by OpenAI). This was also a topic of conversation in the book. Specifically, how this can be used to spread misinformation and weaken trust in society. I ask that you continue to have skepticism in the systems you are helping build and be aware that there are people in society who may not have the technical awareness of AI, and they could be misled or exploited. So, it is important to be at the forefront of making sure this does not occur.

To conclude, I hope you remember Joy's message about AI being limited to what it can do. Although it continues to improve exponentially, it cannot replace the conversations needed to be had in society. Especially when it comes to the regulation of AI systems and where to include and not to include these systems. It is important to have communication where ALL members of society can be involved since AI is being interwoven in so many areas of life and across industries. We cannot rely on technology to fix problems rooted in inequality; these issues require human discussion, regulation, and collective responsibility.

I hope the lessons we learned from this book stay with you and guide the way you think about fairness, transparency, and accountability. With all that being said, let's keep striving to make these principles a reality.

With hope you are still learning every day,

Eric Ortega Rodriguez